

Hamlet

DRAMATIS PERSONAE

Ghost of Hamlet, *the late King of Denmark*

King Claudius, *his brother*

Queen Gertrude of Denmark, *widow of King Hamlet, now wife of Claudius*

Prince Hamlet, *son of King Hamlet and Queen Gertrude*

Polonius, *a lord*

Laertes, *son of Polonius*

Ophelia, *daughter of Polonius*

Reynaldo, *servant of Polonius*

Horatio, *a friend of Prince Hamlet*

Rosencrantz, *a friend of Prince Hamlet*

Guildenstern, *a friend of Prince Hamlet*

Francisco, *a soldier*

Barnardo, *a soldier*

Marcellus, *a soldier*

Valtemand, *a courtier*

Cornelius, *a courtier*

Osric, *a courtier*

Gentlemen, *courtiers*

A Sailor

Two Clowns, a gravedigger and his companion

A Priest

Fortinbras, *Prince of Norway*

A Captain in his army

Ambassadors from England

Players, who play the parts of the

Prologue, Player King, Player

Queen, and Lucianus, in *The Mousetrap*

Lords, messengers, attendants, guards, soldiers, followers of
Laertes, sailors

ATCHING OR READING *Hamlet* for the first time or the twentieth, an observer cannot help being struck, I think, by how much of the play has passed into our common language. Indeed, as many commentators have observed, the experience of *Hamlet* is almost always that of *recognition*, of recalling, remembering, or identifying some already-known phrase or image. It could be said that in the context of modern culture—global culture as well as Anglophone culture—one never does encounter *Hamlet* “for the first time.” Instead the play provides a resonant cultural echo, both forming and reflecting concepts—turns of speech, types of character, philosophical ideas—that seem to preexist any single experience of the play, and at the same time to be disseminated from it.

Nor is it only the great set pieces, the philosophical touchstones, that

linger in the imagination: the “To be, or not to be” soliloquy, with its passionate broodings on death and the life hereafter (3.1.58); Hamlet’s advice to the players (“Speak the speech, I pray you, as I pronounced it to you—trippingly on the tongue,” since “the purpose of playing” is “to hold as ’twere the mirror up to nature” [3.2.1–2, 18–20]); or the calm assurance, voiced in the last act, that the readiness is all, that “[t]here’s a divinity that shapes our ends, / Rough-hew them how we will” (5.2.10–11). It is not surprising that we remember these passages, for their beauty and for their profound ideas. They are among the greatest in the English language. But there are other, more particular and private lines that also seem somehow to have become part of our culture, and for less explainable reasons, lines that seem minor, even trivial. Why should we remember “Alas, poor Yorick,” or that “[s]omething is rotten in the state of Denmark,” or that “there are more things in heaven and earth, Horatio, / Than are dreamt of in your philosophy,” or that “[t]he lady protests too much, methinks”? Proper names and specific terms, all—Yorick, Denmark, Horatio, the lady. Yet they are for us something else, something more “universal.” When we hear someone say “Alas, poor Yorick,” we do not think that he or she is speaking of Hamlet’s childhood jester. We know that what is at stake is rather the general case of mortality and the human condition, that reaches but to dust. When we are told that “[s]omething is rotten in the state of Denmark” we do not think first of pollution problems in Scandinavia, but rather of a generally corrupt society or situation, a pervasive decay. That someone, anyone, “protests too

much” has become a common way of underscoring her, or his, disingenuous-ness. Few of those who quote or adapt this line will recall that it refers to the Player Queen in “The Murder of Gonzago,” *Hamlet's* play-within-the-play

Hamlet is one of the most peculiar, private, and detailed among all of Shakespeare's plays. At first glance it does not seem “universal” at all. Fratricide, an incestuous marriage, a prince who pretends to be mad and contemplates death in a spirit of overwhelming melancholy, a young girl who is in fact driven mad, and who, in her madness, drowns herself. What is it about this odd play, derived from older sources—the twelfth-century legend of Amleth, told by the Danish author known as Saxo the Grammarian, which was later adapted into French by François de Belleforest in 1570, the primary source for the supposed *ur-Hamlet*, or original *Hamlet*, a lost play scholars speculate about—that has mined the play into our consciousness to such a degree? What makes *Hamletw'ith* its many textual variants, its First or “bad” Quarto, Second Quarto, and Folio texts, the most famous of all English dramas and the most admired and quoted of literary documents?

What we have of the imagined *ur-Hamlet* survives in a fragmentary mention of a pale “ghost who cried so miserably at the Theatre like an oyster wife, *Hamlet, revenge*,” so that “Hamlet, revenge” became a common saying of the period, a kind of tagline or joke, this supposed source itself a kind of ghost, existing only in memory, reconstructed in imagination. And the same might be said of the “bad quarto” of 1601, an early

published version that notoriously varies from the text we “know” as *Hamlet*, so that, for example, the play's most famous speech reads, “To be or not to be, I there's the point, / To Die, to sleep, is that all? I all: / No, to sleep, to dream, I mary there it goes....” (“I” in early modern English is another way of spelling “aye;” “mary” is the same word as “marry,” an interjection of surprise or indignation.) This First Quarto is now again valued by scholars as a likely account of the play in performance—the text was probably written down from memory by a secondary player—and it has been produced successfully on the modern stage. Moving more quickly than the version remastered by the Folio editors for the printed text and cherished by generations of poets and philosophers for its long passages of ruminative reflection, the “bad quarto,” now better described simply as Quarto 1, is yet another example of the ways in which Shakespeare in his time, and Shakespeare on the stage instead of the page, differs from the “Shakespeare” who has become a sage cultural authority.

The play's title, taken from the Second Quarto, *The Tragical History of Hamlet, Prince of Denmark*, indicates that we are dealing with both a personal and a political or dynastic situation, with Hamlet the prince and with Hamlet the man. Ophelia tells us what he was like before the play began, before the events that have festered to produce the rottenness that now is Denmark. Her recollection of this ideal young prince is closely akin to Lady Percy's memory of her heroic husband, Harry Percy, or Hotspur, at the beginning of *Henry IV Part 2*, after she has received news

of his death. To Lady Percy, Hotspur “was indeed the glass / Wherein the noble youth did dress themselves” (2 *Henry IV* 2.3.21–22), the mirror or model for a generation. Likewise, Ophelia paints a picture of a Hamlet who was once a cynosure, a brilliant center of attraction:

The courtier's, soldier's, scholar's, eye, tongue, sword,
Th'expectancy and rose of the fair state,
The glass of fashion and the mould of form,
Th'observed of all observers....

Hamlet 3.1.150–153

Hamlet bears the same name as his father, the former King, and his play is a private chronicle, the story of a history gone awry, and wrenched into tragedy. He is a public and a private man, and, presumably, the heir to the throne. Why is Hamlet not the new King? He says that his uncle Claudius “[p]opped in between th election and my hopes” (5.2.66), and it is not enough to say, as footnotes dutifully do, that the Danish monarchy was elected rather than passed down from father to son. “Election” here of course has its older meaning of being chosen by a group of supporters; there were no ballot boxes in medieval Denmark, nor in early modern England. Our modern sense of “acclamation” is appropriate here: we see it in practice in the play both in the people's call “Laertes shall be king” (4.5.104) and in Hamlet's own declaration at the point of death, “I do prophesy th'election lights / On Fortinbras. He has my dying

voice" (5.2.297-298).

There is an uneasiness and an ambiguity, then, in the very title of this play, despite its apparent straightforwardness, and this sense of uneasiness and ambiguity is set forth with great effect in an early exchange between Hamlet the father and Hamlet the son. "Remember me," cries the ghost of old Hamlet, and the son Hamlet replies, "Remember thee? / Ay, thou poor ghost, while memory holds a seat / In this distracted globe" (1.5.91, 95-97). What is the "distracted globe" of which he speaks? The primary sense of his metaphor refers to his head, his troubled mind. As long as I have a memory, he says—as long as I live—I will remember you, and what you have told me. But the literal sense of "globe" is not absent here. The world of the play is itself "distracted," maddened, diseased. Old Hamlet has been poisoned, and the poison affects not only the King, but the state. We know from plays like *Richard II* and the *Henry IV* plays, and even from *Julius Caesar*, a play written in the same years as *Hamlet*, that when the king is weak, so too is the kingdom. When there is corruption at the top, the land and its people are likewise corrupted and infected. Thus in this play the madness that Hamlet assumes is a madness already present in the state, for the king is the state. Hamlet's "antic disposition," his feigned temperament of the fool and madman, is an objective correlative for the condition of his country and its rule. The world, or "globe," of *Hamlet* the play is deliberately and insistently paralleled to the mind, or "globe," of Hamlet the man. Thus Hamlet the character wears an "inky cloak"—associated, as we will see, with the many scenes of writing that

will be depicted in the course of the play. Gertrude, Hamlet's mother, will call his dark costume his "nightly colour" (1.2.68), and the play's world, too, wears a cloak of night, the darkness in which the sentries stumble over one another at the beginning of the play, and the inner darkness of the "black and grainèd spots" that Gertrude is made to acknowledge in her soul.

The world of the play is in a sense a metaphor for the consciousness of its protagonist, and its characters have relationships with Hamlet the prince that are both realistically personal and allusively psychological. The Ghost is both the shade of Hamlet's father, come to stir him, in traditional Elizabethan and Senecan fashion, to revenge, and also a kind of superego, a conscience-prodder, inseparable from Hamlet himself. We may notice that the Ghost speaks only to Hamlet, and, in the scene in the Queen's closet, or private room, is seen only by him. Gertrude sees "nothing," and thinks she sees all there is to see. Likewise Horatio is unquestionably a "real" character, Hamlet's fellow student at the University of Wittenberg in Germany (significantly, the home, as well, of the legendary Doctor Faustus and the real Martin Luther), but he is also a kind of internal censor, a voice that might almost come out of Hamlet's own mind, screening out unacceptable ideas and memories, confident that ghosts don't exist, and cautioning Hamlet in the last act against considering "too curiously" the question of what happens to the body after death.

There is, then, a strong and deliberate parallelism between the mind of Hamlet and the world of Denmark. But there is also, needless to say, a third important meaning to the phrase “this distracted globe” when uttered in the context of Shakespeare's company's history, for *The Tragical History of Hamlet, Prince of Denmark* was staged in the new Globe theater the company had built in the Bankside district of London, and the “distracted globe” is also the mysterious world of the theater, in which we sit as spectators. Hamlet will speak in his dying moments to the onstage onlookers who are “mutes or audience to this act” (5.2.277), unwitting bystanders, and the audience in the theater, from Shakespeare's time to the present, is part of this group. It is in our memory, as well as in theirs, that the tragedy lives on and the story is retold. We need not point to the omnipresent theatrical metaphors or the infinite sequence of plays-within-the-play to see how Hamlet's story has become, for every audience, its own. Like a series of Russian dolls, nested one inside another, or the infinite regress of a theatrical or pictorial illusion (the man on the trademark Quaker oats box, holding a box on which there is a man holding a box), the plays and fictions of *Hamlet* nest inside one another, until we are no longer sure where to place the boundaries of reality and illusion. Hamlet's story becomes the story of a confrontation with consciousness, and it is this story that becomes the haunting chronicle Horatio must live to retell. In its history, as well as its dramatic structure, *Hamlet* the play has itself become a mirror held up to nature, like the “glass of fashion and the mould of form” that was Hamlet the prince. It is

perhaps for this reason that so many critics and philosophers have seen themselves in the character. As Samuel Taylor Coleridge famously remarked, "I have a smack of Hamlet myself, if I may say so."¹

In suggesting that these three worlds—the world of Hamlet's mind and imagination; the physical, political, and "historical" world of Denmark; and the world of dramatic fiction and play—are parallel to and superimposed upon one another, I am suggesting, also, that the play is about the whole question of boundaries, thresholds, and liminality or border crossing: boundary disputes between Norway and Denmark, boundaries between youth and age, boundaries between reality and imagination, between audience and actor. And these boundaries seem to be constantly shifting. The most inexorable boundary possible would seem to be that between life and death, yet the play opens with the appearance of a ghost, a spirit come from the grave, as well as from the contemporary Elizabethan stage, where such evocative and minatory figures were popular. Even language seems to lose its boundaries. Hamlet says to a startled Horatio, "My father—methinks I see my father" (1.2.183). "O where, my lord?" is the astonished reply (184). "In my mind's eye, Horatio" (184). This is all well and good—the "sighting" is safely metaphorical. But only four lines later, Horatio, this play's man of common sense and ultimate rationality, will say, "My lord, I think I saw him yesternight" (188). And this leap into the world of illusion, this crumbling of the expected boundaries between the real and the fictive or imagined, is an essential part of the play's methods. There is, as Polonius will

remark in another connection, method in its madness.

If, of all of Shakespeare's plays, only *Hamlet* had somehow survived, if we had only *Hamlet* to represent his theater and his dramatic achievement, we would still regard Shakespeare as a brilliant playwright, and we would have a very good idea of what the early modern stage looked like and how it worked. For one of the central tropes of *Hamlet* the play (and indeed of *Hamlet* the prince and player) is what is called "metatheater," or "metadrama," the discussion of theater and playing within a play—the play talking about its own materials, and the self-referential gestures toward the world as a stage (or Globe).

As befits a play about the "purpose of playing" in the widest sense, *Hamlet* provides an excellent guide to the use of the early modern stage, and to the thematic interchangeability of stage and world. At the end of the first act, for example, the Ghost "cries under the stage," commanding, "Swear.... Swear.... Swear," from the trapdoor leading to the "hell" beneath the stage. And in the graveyard scene in the fifth act, Ophelia's grave is the same open "trap." The symmetry would not have been lost on the spectators. The "heavens" above the stage—a covering, ornamented with suns and stars, that protected the actors from the elements—are explicitly compared by Hamlet to the world outside the theater ("this brave o'erhanging, this majestic roof fretted with golden fire" (2.2.291–292). In this, one of his greatest existential speeches, Hamlet guardedly explains his melancholy mood—the fact that he has "lost all [his] mirth"—to his opportunistic, and ultimately treacherous,

schoolfellows Rosen-crantz and Guildenstern. Unlike many of the great soliloquies in this play, this famous set piece on “man” is written in prose.

The balcony above the stage would have been used as a guard platform by the sentries in the opening scene, with its startling first line—“Who's there?”—flung out not only at the newcomer, another sentry, but also at the audience. “Who's there?” and then, “Nay, answer me.” (Recall that this scene of darkness was played in full light, in the middle of the afternoon, and this scene of bitter cold was played in full warmth, in the middle of the summer.) The two doors behind the stage would have gotten much use, for royal entrances and exits, for Ophelia's comings and goings, for the political scenes with the Norwegian Prince Fortinbras and his army, and, of course, for the “maiméd rites” of the funeral procession for the dead Ophelia. The discovery space behind the stage would have been used for Polonius hiding behind the arras in Gertrude's closet—invading her private space.

In the refitting and revising of the play-within-the-play, *The Mousetrap*, we have a good example of how Renaissance plays were adapted for different occasions, sometimes by a second or third playwright. Hamlet asks whether the players could learn “some dozen or sixteen lines” he will insert, to do the work (the detective work, the cultural work) he needs the play to do, in testing Claudius's guilt. *The Mousetrap* is a dramatic fiction that resembles, very closely, what he thinks happened in “real life”—the murder of the previous King, the good King, Hamlet's father. Later in the play Hamlet once again crucially revises a script, in this

case the sealed letter from King Claudius, carried by Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, requesting the King of England to cut off Hamlet's head, and again he will imagine it as a staged action: "Ere I could make a prologue to my brains, / They had begun the play" (5.2.31–32).

Through a clever use of playing and of players, and of the repertoire of this particular traveling company, Hamlet will trap his uncle Claudius into a damning sign of guilt—evidence that he, Claudius, is responsible for the death of Hamlet's father, which made possible his own accession to the throne, and to the Queen. The acting company consists of adult players, described by Polonius as "[t]he best actors in the world, either for tragedy, comedy, history, pastoral, pastoral-comical, historical-pastoral, tragical-historical, tragical-comical-historical-pastoral, scene individable or poem unlimited" (2.2.379–382). They play a wide repertoire, from the tragedies of Seneca to the comedies of Plautus. This list, so pedantically offered, is a deliberate parody of the mixed modes that were beginning to appear on the stage, and the academic, comically Aristotelian desire to classify them.

The play's events will turn in part on the visit of this group of traveling players to Elsinore, in Denmark. Why are the players traveling, rather than playing in a theater in the city? As Hamlet points out, they were better off in the city, in terms of both their reputation and their capacity to turn a profit. But we learn from Rosencrantz and Guildenstern that the fashion for child players, the boy actors performing satires in the private theaters, has driven the adult company out of the city. Hamlet, a

self-confessed aficionado of the theater, provides a good brief description of the kinds of actors, and parts, there were in sixteenth-century companies, as well as an ironic commentary on the fictionality of real-life roles: "He that plays the King shall be welcome; his majesty shall have tribute of me. The adventurous Knight shall use his foil and target [sword and shield], the Lover shall not sigh gratis [without payment], ... the Humorous Man [someone governed by the one of humors, which were thought to influence the emotions, such as anger or melancholy]..., the Clown ..., the Lady ..." (2.2.308–312). Hamlet has met these players before, and he greets them as old friends. The First Player—the main actor, the star—has grown a beard since he saw him last; the boy who plays female parts (addressed by Hamlet as "my young lady and mistress") has not only grown taller, his voice may soon be changing, rendering him no longer fit for women's roles.

By the time the players arrive, we have already seen in Hamlet a certain tendency to self-dramatization. He thinks in theatrical terms. He moralizes on his mourning clothes as a kind of "show," or external display. He assumes the role of fool or antic, with a disarranged costume to match. Even as late as the graveyard scene, he will speak bitterly about face-painting and makeup, comparing the skull of Yorick to "a fine lady"—"let her paint an inch thick, to this favour she must come"—and he has already said as much to the living Ophelia, an innocent victim, in the scene in which he demonstrates his "madness" to her: "I have heard of your paintings, too, well enough. God hath given you one face, and

you make yourselves another. You jig, you amble, you lisp" (3.1.142–144). This is an unflattering account of the behavior of women, but it is also a description of the behavior of professional actors, who paint, and who amble, jig, and lisp onstage. Lipping is often associated in Shakespeare with affectation: Rosalind counsels Jaques, "Look you lisp, and wear strange suits" (*As You Like It* 4.1.29–30), and Berowne mocks an ornate courtier as an "ape of form" who can "lisp" to women and men. The jig, a lively dance—English, Scottish, or Irish— was a common element of performance, especially by clowns and fools, on the stage, and is an aspect of the improvised behavior Hamlet warns the players against in his advice to them.

Hamlet's famous "advice to the players" shows us something of the tension between the relatively naturalistic acting favored by Shakespeare's company— confiding in the audience, the soliloquy as a kind of voiced thought—and the older and more bombastic acting style inherited from the medieval mystery plays, and still favored by some of Shakespeare's contemporaries, like Edward Alleyn, the chief tragedian of the rival company, the Lord Admiral's Men. Here is Hamlet:

Speak the speech, I pray you, as I pronounced it to you—trippingly on the tongue; but if you mouth it, as many of your players do, I had as lief the town-crier had spoke my lines. Nor do not saw the air too much with your hand, thus, but use all gently; for in the very torrent, tempest, and as I may say the whirlwind of your passion,

you must acquire and beget a temperance that may give it smoothness. O, it offends me to the soul to hear a robustious, periwig-pated fellow tear a passion to tatters, to very rags, to split the ears of the groundlings, who for the most part are capable of nothing but inexplicable dumb shows and noise. I would have such a fellow whipped for o'erdoing Termagant. It out-Herods Herod. Pray you avoid it.... Be not too tame, neither; but let your own discretion be your tutor. Suit the action to the word, the word to the action, with this special observance: that you o'erstep not the modesty of nature. For anything so overdone is from the purpose of playing, whose end, both at the first and now, was and is to hold as 'twere the mirror up to nature, to show virtue her own feature, scorn her own image, and the very age and body of the time his form and pressure.

3.2.1-22

Hamlet warns against overacting, and bellowing, and strutting, and clowns who improvise to get a laugh, and who distract the spectators from the meaning of the play. This is Hamlet's "advice to the players." What is his advice to himself?

We find it, of course, in the extraordinary soliloquies, the internal monologues, the debates and discussions with himself for which this play is famous— and justly so. It is to a very great extent the soliloquies

that have made the play the favorite of poets and philosophers, not to mention actors and directors. In each of the first four acts we find Hamlet either stepping forward or being left alone to ruminate to himself. "I'll be with you straight," he says. "Go a little before," or "Now I am alone." And, left alone onstage, with only us for company and confidants, he speaks:

O that this too too solid flesh would melt,
Thaw, and resolve itself into a dew,
Or that the Everlasting had not fixed
His canon 'gainst self-slaughter! O God, O God,
How weary, stale, flat, and unprofitable
Seem to me all the uses of this world!

1. 2.129-134

In act 2, scene 2, we hear his disparaging comparison of himself to the First Player, who is only an actor, not a prince, and yet is able to show more grief in a pretended cause than Hamlet can show in a real one:

O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I!
Is it not monstrous that this player here,
But in a fiction, in a dream of passion,
Could force his soul so to his whole conceit
That from her working all his visage wanned,

Tears in his eyes, distraction in 's aspect,
A broken voice, and his whole function suiting
With forms to his conceit? And all for nothing.
For Hecuba!

What's Hecuba to him, or he to Hecuba,
That he should weep for her? What would he do
Had he the motive and the cue for passion
That I have? He would drown the stage with tears.

2.2.527-539

The soliloquy in the fourth act, Hamlet's rebuke to himself for failing to act in a good cause, is couched, like the second soliloquy, as a negative self-comparison. Why can he not be more like Fortinbras, the noble soldier avenging his father's defeat?

How all occasions do inform against me
And spur my dull revenge! What is a man
If his chief good and market of his time
Be but to sleep and feed?—a beast, no more.
Sure he that made us with such large discourse, v
Looking before and after, gave us not
That capability and god-like reason
To fust in us unused. Now whether it be
Bestial oblivion, or some craven scruple

Of thinking too precisely on the event—
A thought which, quartered, hath but one part wisdom
And ever three parts coward—I do not know
Why yet I live to say “This thing's to do,”
Sith I have cause, and will, and strength, and means,
To do't. Examples gross as earth exhort me.

4.4.9.22–9.36

Fortinbras, by contrast, he calls a “delicate and tender prince” willing to risk everything: “Exposing what is mortal and unsure / To all that fortune, death, and danger dare, / Even for an eggshell.” His troops battle over a plot of ground that is not even big enough to bury the dead.

These passages, with their rich imagery and their unerring rhythmic ebb and flow, are among the most moving and complex speeches in our literature. But it is the soliloquy in the third act, “To be, or not to be,” that has become the hallmark of interiority and consciousness, the speech that—quoted, parodied, parsed, and pondered—has come to define modernity and modern self-consciousness, the birth, in effect, of the modern subject, of modern subjectivity itself:

To be, or not to be; that is the question:
Whether 'tis nobler in the mind to suffer
The slings and arrows of outrageous fortune,
Or to take arms against a sea of troubles,

And, by opposing, end them. To die, to sleep—
No more, and by a sleep to say we end
The heartache and the thousand natural shocks
That flesh is heir to—'tis a consummation
Devoutly to be wished. To die, to sleep.
To sleep, perchance to dream. Ay, there's the rub,
For in that sleep of death what dreams may come
When we have shuffled off this mortal coil
Must give us pause....

3.1.58–70

The diction—the single string of relentless monosyllables, the repetition of the infinitive “to be”—draws a verbal picture of the anguish of thought. And this almost unbearable moment of full consciousness—*too* full consciousness—is what we think of as the condition and the tragedy of modernity. Actors have tried to find new ways to pronounce this speech. In his film of *Hamlet*, Kenneth Branagh speaks it while looking in a mirror—a three-sided mirror, where the actor, seen in full length, beholds, and displays, many selves, many versions of himself. Which is the real one?

We might compare “To be, or not to be” with a similar kind of construction—say, “To do, or not to do.” This is the kind of quandary that afflicts Macbeth, as we’ll see. It is given voice in a great speech:

My thought, whose murder yet is but fantastical,
Shakes so my single state of man that function
Is smothered in surmise, and nothing is
But what is not.

Macbeth 1.3.138-141

"To do, or not to do" is also the problem that confronts Othello, as he trembles on the brink of a dreadful deed. But although Hamlet likewise contemplates action, contemplates murder, contemplates revenge, it is *being*, not *doing*, that has made this character the mirror that subsequent writers, philosophers, and critics have held up to human nature. Being—and remembering—because the essence of the human animal, and the pain and joy of the human condition, are in this play directly linked to memory. "Remember me," cries the Ghost—and later, when Hamlet is in his mother's closet, "Do not forget." Hamlet reflects:

Remember thee?

Ay, thou poor ghost, while memory holds a seat
In this distracted globe. Remember thee?

Yea, from the table of my memory

I'll wipe away all trivial fond records,

All saws of books, all forms, all pressures past,

That youth and observation copied there,

And thy commandment all alone shall live

Within the book and volume of my brain.

Hamlet 1.5.97-103

Friedrich Nietzsche saw memory as that which distinguishes human beings from animals. Cattle forget, and so they are happy. Humans remember, and so they suffer. "[I]n the smallest and greatest happiness," he wrote in his essay on history, "there is always one thing that makes it happiness: the power of forgetting."² Human beings, both individually and as a people, "must know the right time to forget as well as the right time to remember."³ And in the same essay Nietzsche also wrote, with a glance, unmistakably, at *Hamlet*, that the past has to be forgotten "if it is not to become the gravedigger of the present."⁴ The gravedigger—or the ghost? The ghost of Hamlet's father beckons him toward the past, and toward revenge. Hamlet is a ghost of himself when he appears, "unbraced" and "down-gyvèd," in Ophelia's chamber. Ghosts in Shakespeare hark back to *Richard III* and *Julius Caesar*, and will appear again in *Macbeth* and in *Cymbeline*, but ghostliness is never embodied as powerfully, or as multiply, as in this play, where ultimately everyone is a ghost.

The play begins, as it ends, in silence, with a dumb show, here the appearance of the Ghost. Horatio and the sentries serve as chorus, interpreting as best they can what they have seen. Twice the Ghost appears, each time interrupting the spectators' conversation, and although it seems about to speak it twice stalks off without a word. We cannot know, they cannot know, what to make of this. All of us, on and off the stage,

are “mutes or audience” to this act. Briefly but importantly, the Ghost is succeeded by another figure, also costumed in a significant way. “But look,” says Horatio, “the morn in russet mantle clad / Walks o’er the dew of yon high eastern hill” (1.1.147–148). It is the sun. The pun on sun/son, sunlight and a father’s son, is reinforced in the next scene by Hamlet’s wry joke, “I am too much i’tsun” (1.2.67). But this reassuring glimpse of natural light, vividly costumed to the mind’s eye in its “russet mantle,” stands in sharp contrast to the darkness that succeeds it, the darkness that is Denmark, where cries for torches, artificial light, will punctuate and bring to a premature end the play-within-the-play in the great central *Mousetrap* scene: “Give me some light. Away” (3.2.247).

The “russet mantle” of the sun, and the “complete steel,” the medieval armor of the Ghost, introduce as well the crucial question of costume, in this play whose fundamental themes are all related to the very act of acting. Dumb shows, stage lights, curtains, makeup, and costumes. For now Hamlet makes his appearance, in the “inky cloak” that is to be the first of the three costumes he will wear in this play: his inky cloak; his antic disposition, “unbraced,” “down-gyvèd;” and his traveler’s sea gown, “scarfed” about him. Again it is useful to imagine the stage as a visual spectacle, glittering with jewels, torches, and liveried attendants. In the center, the King and Queen, splendid in silks and furs; Claudius bejeweled and be-ringed, his head crowned, the very emblem of conspicuous consumption. And to the side, Hamlet, a mute spectator of all this magnificence, startling in black from head to toe. “Good Hamlet, cast thy

nightly colour off" (2.1.68). This is the Queen, in quest of domestic peace, almost surely (is she?) unaware of the murder of her former husband by her present one. But Hamlet is quick to remind her that there is more than one kind of costume, and that to seem a mourner is not necessarily to be one, just as to seem a king may also be a fiction:

Seems, madam? Nay, it *is*. I know not "seems."
'Tis not alone my inky cloak, good-mother,
Nor customary suits of solemn black,
Nor windy suspiration of forced breath,
No, nor the fruitful river in the eye,
Nor the dejected haviour of the visage,
Together with all form, moods, shows of grief
That can denote me truly. These indeed "seem,"
For they are actions that a man might play;
But I have that within which passeth show—
These but the trappings and the suits of woe.

1.2.76-86

Forms, modes, shapes, trappings. Seem, play, act, show. Fake sighs, and dejected looks. This is the language of acting, and acting is what Hamlet sees all around him—a player king and a player queen, acting at grief, and acting it badly. Claudius out-Heroding Herod, out-Hamleting Hamlet, displaying exactly the kind of excessive, overblown acting against which

Hamlet will counsel the visiting players. Herod, a familiar figure from medieval drama, was the theater's image of a bombastic king, but it is also the case that he, like Claudius, married his brother's wife. Hamlet's speech here is in fact a kind of advice to the players, to Claudius and to Gertrude, and it points up the most pernicious kind of illusion, the purpose of which is to cheat and conceal. In a play so consistently attentive to the material details of the stage, such pernicious illusions often take the imagistic form of makeup and face-painting: the unction to "skin and film the ulcerous place" (3.4.138); the "harlot's cheek, beautied with plastering art" (3.1.53). And, as Hamlet will say of "my lady" and the skull in the graveyard, "let her paint an inch thick, to this favour she must come" (5.1.179).

In act 1, scene 2, his first appearance in the play, Hamlet is both audience and critic. He sees the performance of Claudius, and in effect he gives it a bad review. It is not convincing. One result of this crucial perception, that all around him people are merely masquerading as mourners, acting grief rather than feeling it, is to make Hamlet reject his own costume. If others can counterfeit grief by merely wearing "the trappings and the suits of woe," what is to become of real grief? Hamlet's mourning clothes have become a "show," despite him, in the politic air of Denmark. He has become unwittingly and unwillingly complicit in Claudius's display. His "customary suits of solemn black" (1.2.78), the appropriate costume for mourning, are compromised and sullied by the other "customs" that have crept into the Danish court. Thus Hamlet will

later speak of the "monster custom," of "damned custom," and Horatio of the "custom" of the gravedigger's callousness (3.4.151.1; 3.4.36; 5.1.63). But his suit of mourning will become a custom more honored in the breach than in the observance, better abandoned than worn, because wearing it aligns him with Danish hypocrisy. He needs a new costume, a new role, to demonstrate the sincerity of his grief and his anger, and he finds that new costume in the "antic disposition" of madness. The allowed fool, or licensed fool, in a royal or noble household was a paid dependent whose social role was both to amuse and to instruct, cloaking moral lessons in jokes and mumming. Hamlet the prince now becomes his own household fool, and allows himself to speak the truth.

It is thought that when the play was first staged Shakespeare himself played the part of the Ghost. Shakespeare's only son, whose name was Hamnet, died in 1596, and Shakespeare's father, John, died in 1601. The play itself, almost obsessively concerned with the relationships between fathers and sons, seems poised across this barrier. And it is with the Ghost, I think, that one should start in approaching and comprehending the world of the play and the problems of Hamlet. Very often, as we have noted in considering the structure of other plays, Shakespeare uses his opening scenes as a kind of cameo, vignette, or miniature of the larger play that will follow, with characters who play no other role. In *Hamlet* we have what is possibly the greatest of these opening scenes, because it develops a mood and a tone that chill the spectator to the core. The night itself is chilly, and the sentries are nervous. "Who's there?" (1.1.1),

Bar-nardo's opening line, ringing out of the darkness, is a challenge not from the sentry on duty but to him, our first hint that the world of the play is inverted, out of joint. From the point of view of a modern or post-modern production, the flung-out line "Who's there?" seems directed almost primarily at the audience, rather than at any character on the stage. Moreover, the challenger is also a sentry, so that these sentries, instead of repelling invaders, find themselves in the confusion of a civil misunderstanding. The challenge comes not from outside Denmark but from within it. And all of this is established within the first five lines.

"Who's there?" "Nay, answer me. Stand and unfold yourself" (1.1.1-2). Barnardo is told to "unfold" himself, ushering in the cloak-and-costume imagery, and also the imagery of folded paper and writing, which will become so predominant later in the play, and at this point there enter upon the stage the more "major" characters of Horatio and Marcellus. We may expect the audience to share the skepticism and rationalism of Horatio—so far, no boundaries of experience have been broken, and there is something reassuring in the colloquialism of his view of the Ghost: "Tush, tush, 'twill not appear" (1.1.28). This would be more reassuring, however, if the Ghost did not, almost immediately, make his appearance, dwarfing, with his "fair and warlike form," all the others upon the stage.

The stage direction says "Enter the Ghost," but the apparition is not so concretely described by the immediate onlookers. It is instead referred to as "this thing" (1.1.19), "this dreaded sight" (23), an "illusion"

(108)—“What, has this thing appeared again tonight?” What else it is remains a question, not an answer, a puzzle that must be solved, and with which even Hamlet will be troubled. Is it “a spirit of health or goblin damned” (1.4.21)? We learn little about it in this first glimpse; it is “like the King that’s dead” (1.1.39), it is dressed in armor, and although Horatio asks it again and again to speak, it will not. We may gather from its refusal that this is not the common or garden-variety ghost, which comes to give an omen of the future, or to tell the location of buried treasure—ideas that the bookish Horatio has probably come upon in his studies. “Thou art a scholar—speak to it, Horatio,” says Marcellus. Ghosts were traditionally to be addressed in Latin, thus Horatio’s studies would fit him for the task. The Ghost disappears at the coming of the dawn that banishes all spirits from walking the earth, and the scene closes with Marcellus’s lovely, though fearful, speech:

It faded on the crowing of the cock.
Some say that ever 'gainst that season comes
Wherein our saviour's birth is celebrated
The bird of dawning singeth all night long;
And then, they say, no spirit can walk abroad,
The nights are wholesome, then no planets strike,
No fairy takes, nor witch hath power to charm,
So hallowed and so gracious is the time.

Similar beliefs about ghosts were articulated in Shakespeare's great "fairy" play, *A Midsummer Night's Dream*, where Puck warns Oberon:

My fairy lord, this must be done with haste,
For night's swift dragons cut the clouds full fast,
And yonder shines Aurora's harbinger,
At whose approach ghosts, wand'ring here and there,
Troop home to churchyards; damnèd spirits all
That in cross-ways and floods have burial
Already to their wormy bed are gone,
For fear lest day should look their shames upon.
They willfully themselves exiled from light,
And must for aye consort with black-browed night.

Dream 3.2.379-388

Ghosts of this sort were the spectral counterparts of the "vagabonds" or "master-less men" against whom an Elizabethan statute had been proclaimed in 1597, including among them traveling actors. All these dangerous wanderers were regarded as deleterious to the order and safety of the state. Marcellus's pious pronouncement, the equivalent of crossing oneself against the threat of unimaginable danger from another world, closes the first scene on a note of purity and watchfulness, with the rising of the sun. It is the last we will see of this natural, almost

pastoral light, for all that Hamlet will proclaim himself “too much i'th sun” (1.2.67). For at this point there enters upon the stage, with much pomp and ceremony, the new King, Claudius of Denmark, accompanied by his queen, Gertrude, and the rest of his retinue.

Claudius's opening speech, beginning the play's second scene, offers the greatest possible contrast to the dignified and mysterious silence of the Ghost. His speech is a model of policy, a masterly reduction of language to formal public utterance. Its very first word is the politician's “though”—a conditional hedge:

Though yet of Hamlet our dear brother's death
The memory be green, and that it us befitted
To bear our hearts in grief and our whole kingdom
To be contracted in one brow of woe,
Yet so far hath discretion fought with nature
That we with wisest sorrow think on him
Together with remembrance of ourselves.

Hamlet 1.2.1–7

Claudius's main clause here refers not to “our dear brother” or his death, but to “ourselves,” that is, himself—the royal “we.” His elegantly turned sentence gestures toward grief but quickly comes back to the real subject, himself, before he reverts to the smooth language of politics:

Therefore our sometime sister, now our queen,

Th'imperial jointress to this warlike state,
Have we as 'twere with a defeated joy
With one auspicious and one dropping eye,
With mirth in funeral and with dirge in marriage,
In equal scale weighing delight and dole,
Taken to wife....

1.2.8-14

The words flow on, smoothly, decoratively Yet when we stop to think about it, there is a serious and troublesome peculiarity about the concept of "our sometime sister, now our queen." The audience of Shakespeare's time would certainly have recalled the difficulties that arose when Queen Elizabeth's father, Henry VIII, sought to divorce his first wife, Catherine of Aragon, who had briefly been married to his older brother, Prince Arthur, in 1501. Arthur died six months after the wedding, and in 1509, when he succeeded to the throne on the death of his father, Henry VII, Henry VIII married the Spanish princess. When, in 1533, Henry sought annulment of the marriage in order to marry the pregnant Anne Boleyn, Elizabeth's mother, the grounds for his petition were found in a passage in Leviticus that said that a marriage between a man and his brother's wife was incestuous ("And if a man shall lie with his brother's wife, it is an unclean thing, he has uncovered his brother's nakedness; they shall be childless" [Leviticus 20:21; see also Leviticus 18:16]).

Although Catherine and Henry had a daughter, the future Queen Mary, they had no son, and Henry took this, conveniently, as proof that the biblical injunction had been broken. In any case, an audience in England around 1600 would not have forgotten the critical events that had brought their present monarch, circuitously, to the throne. Twentieth-century criticism concerned with the “incest motif” in *Hamlet*, and influenced by Freud, often singles out the relationship between Hamlet and his mother. But in the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, Claudius's easy phrase “our sometime sister, now our queen” would have been at least as provocative, and at least as potentially disturbing. Nor is it simple to imagine the other chiasmic couplings of his first speech—“a defeated joy,” “one auspicious and one dropping eye,” “with mirth in funeral and with dirge in marriage”—nor “my cousin Hamlet, and my son” (1.2.64). Meaning runs counter to rhetoric here. We are in part seduced into accepting an association between “mirth” and “dirge,” not because the connection between the two is admirable or logical, but because they nearly rhyme. Can everything be right in such a state, where language contradicts itself so effortlessly, so cosmetically, and where the majesty of the King's public utterance crushes together, almost undetected by his courtly listeners, a comic funeral and a tragic marriage?

The language here has become more than language. It is now part of the play's plot, communicating to the audience in the theater—and to certain listeners onstage—something opposite from what we are apparently being told. If we listen closely, and detect the strain that holds

"mirth" and "funeral" together, we will sense that there is something wrong as surely as we did when we stood in imagination with the shivering sentries to watch the silent figure of the Ghost, in a kind of dumb show. For the appearance of the Ghost in the first scene *is* a dumb show, a "prologue to the omen coming on," a silent, gesturing apparition that invites or demands interpretation. This is the first of several dumb shows in *Hamlet*. Others, as we'll see, will include Ophelia's account of Hamlet's visit to her chamber, and the literal dumb show that prefaces the crucial *Mousetrap* play in the third act. But in his first appearance the speaking King, Claudius, displays at least as much eloquence as the gesturing Ghost. For the moment, at least, he is in control of language, making it jump through hoops, cease to mean what it should. Hamlet will have much reason to distrust "[w]ords, words, words"—or what Claudius himself, in a humbler moment, will call "my most painted word" (3.1.55). The world in which this kind of Claudius-language governs is a topsy-turvy, inverted world—in the Ghost's phrase, "most foul, strange, and unnatural" (1.5.28). It even approaches blasphemy, when we hear, for example, that every time the King drinks, the cannons will blaze away, and "the King's rouse the heavens shall bruit again, / Re-speaking earthly thunder" (1.2.127–128). Properly, thunder is heavenly, not earthly, but in this figure the King, not the gods, is the origin, and the skies can only "re-speak," or echo, what he says and does. By the time Claudius falls to his knees to plead with those heavens, the split between his language and the meaning it cloaks is already too great. "My words fly up," he will

acknowledge, "my thoughts remain below" (3.3.97). The Denmark of this play is a place of inversion and perversion, and there is no greater clue to that fact than the tenor and rhetoric of its language.

This split between words and thought, words and meaning, is essential to the way *Hamlet* works. When the everyday language of human beings cannot be trusted, the only "safe" language is deliberate fiction, plays and lies. The only safe world is the world of the imagination, not the corrupt and uncontrollable world of politics. And all of this Shakespeare sets out for us in the architecture of his first act, as we hear the various voices of characters we have not met before, and learn about them through the plot of language. Thus the third scene of this remarkable first act produces yet another father and another son, this time the old counselor Polonius and his son Laertes, and again, as with Claudius and the reluctant Hamlet, the audience has a chance to hear fatherly advice. Indeed, the whole of the first act is built on the advice of fathers to sons, fathers to children, and it culminates with the awful revelations of Hamlet's father, the Ghost, confirming what we have already begun to suspect: that there *is* something rotten in the state of Denmark.

Polonius's language is not so much the language of policy as it is the language of platitude and homily, the language of aphorism and adage, the language of other people's "wisdom." Many of his bromides can be found in collections of proverbial wisdom from the period, and a good number have found their way into political speeches by U.S. legislators read into the *Congressional Record*. The "wisdom" of Polonius offers

perhaps the best instance—other than the utterances of Machiavellian Iago—of words from Shakespeare taken out of context, what I have called “Bartlett’s Familiar Shakespeare.” Sayings like “Neither a borrower nor a lender be” or “[T]he apparel oft proclaims the man” or “This above all, / To thine own self be true” seem to have a certain moral or ethical force when considered in the abstract, but uttered onstage by a dramatic character who has been interpreted in every mode from hapless wise counselor to doddering old fool, these same words begin to coruscate with inadvertent irony. Certainly Laertes, a man who loves his father, takes Polonius’s advice, affectionately, with a grain of salt. Claudius decorated his language with sounding phrases that plastered over and concealed his harsher meanings. Polonius reduces himself to the even more anodyne level of the completely impersonal and banal word. The advice may be wiser than the speaker. Modern quoters cite “Shakespeare” at their peril when they are actually, and recognizably, quoting Shakespearean characters carefully crafted to be at variance with their own language. One of this playwright’s most substantial achievements is that, whenever he cites truisms or platitudes, he puts them in the mouths of suspect speakers, something that the “Bartlett’s”—or, now, the Internet—approach to quotation entirely fails to acknowledge, with the result that the irony turns back upon the quoter. If every critic and philosopher wants to find a smack of Hamlet in himself, no one wants to “be” Polonius.

Some critics over the years have identified Elizabeth’s chief secretary of

state, William Cecil, Lord Burghley, who died in 1598, as the original of Polonius in *Hamlet*, while others have pointed to the name Polonius (which replaces “Corambis” in the First Quarto) as a topical reference to a Polish statesman. A famous anecdote details Queen Elizabeths rhetorical triumph over a long-winded Polish ambassador, whom she harangued, extemporaneously, in Latin, a language in which she had been schooled but which had “lain long in rusting.”⁵ Certainly, as Joan Landis has noted, references to “Poles” and Poland appear importantly elsewhere in the play.⁶ But in assessing the relative cultural visibility of sources and analogues, on the one hand, and vivid dramatic characters, on the other, the ambivalent victory here must surely go to Shakespeare's Polonius, whose persona and name have taken on almost as much currency as that of a figure like Falstaff whose own origins in a historical figure called Sir John Old-castle have also been eclipsed by the liveliness of Shakespeare's portrayal.

The family tableau quickly reveals its darker side. Applying his own rather suspicious standards to others, Polonius warns his daughter Ophelia about the untrustworthiness of Hamlet's words—“his vows ... are brokers” (1.3.127)—and forbids her, significantly, to talk to him in the future: “Lord Hamlet is a prince out of thy star” (2.2.141). Laertes has the same opinion. Hamlet “may not,” he advises his sister, “as unvalued persons do / Carve for himself.” (1.3.19–20). They warn her against seduction and unchastity, sowing the dramatic seeds for her later breakdown into madness. Indeed, the play repeatedly associates the “rotten” thing that

male characters need to be on guard against with women and female sexuality. Hamlet's bitter and despairing instruction to Ophelia, "Get thee to a nunnery" (3.1.122), incorporates the two apparently opposite meanings of the word, for in Elizabethan slang a "nunnery" was a brothel. This fear of the power of women and of their excessive capacity for desire at times produces an almost paranoid level of surveillance, in Polonius's case not only over his daughter, Ophelia (whom he will "loose" to Hamlet in the lobby as if Hamlet were a stallion and Ophelia a mare, as he and Claudius overlook the scene), but also over his son. For no sooner has Laertes departed for Paris than Polonius sends spies after him, instructed to offer up slanderous accusations of Laertes' drinking, swearing, and "drabbing" (visiting whores) to see if they yield similar gossip and confidences. Such a technique, to "by indirections find directions out" and by a "bait of falsehood" catch a "carp of truth," was a not unfamiliar one employed by the Elizabethan spy network, under the direction of Cecil's colleague and successor, Sir Francis Walsingham. Used by a father against his own son, and immediately after the genial imparting of moral advice in the guise of a farewell, this cynical proceeding contrasts both with Claudius's manifest and grandiose duplicity and with the anguished truth-telling between father and son, old Hamlet and young Hamlet, that will occupy the stage in the scene to follow.

For it is at this point in the dramatic action that the Ghost once again appears, as the scene shifts away from the plush and politic court to the stark cold air of the night watch. The play's first act is encapsulated by

the Ghost's appearance, in scenes 4 and 5. The questions raised by the initial appearance of the inexplicable and silent Ghost have lingered all this time, and finally, with Hamlet, the spectators in the theater confront "this dreaded sight," this "illusion." Once more it mounts to the stage, and, for the first time, it speaks. To whom does it speak? To Hamlet alone, and to us, insofar as we are, for this moment, part of the "distracted globe" that is Hamlet's consciousness. Horatio had four times asked it to speak, and received nothing but a sign. Now it speaks to Hamlet, and the language of Hamlet the father to Hamlet the son is charged with a special kind of intensity: "I am thy father's spirit" (1.5.9). "I'll call thee Hamlet, / King, father, royal Dane" (1.4.25–26). Here is a different kind of advice from father to son. Yet Hamlet speaks of his "prophetic soul." He has imagined, again in his "mind's eye," the tale of murder that the Ghost will tell. How can we divide the world inside Hamlet's mind from that of the "real world" of Denmark? What is this "illusion," which comes to tell Hamlet what he already half knows? For what does it stand, and why does it stir Hamlet to a feigned, creative madness, an antic disposition—to literally playing the fool?

For a long time scholars have debated the theological and religious implications of the Ghost, a debate well articulated in Eleanor Prosser's *Hamlet and Revenge* and in a number of subsequent studies.⁷ The Catholic belief in purgatory was not shared or permitted by the new Protestant sects, and Hamlet's worry about whether this is a "spirit of health or goblin damned" depends, to a certain extent, upon whether or

not one could or should believe in a good or “honest” Ghost. Old Hamlet describes himself as “[d]oomed for a certain term to walk the night, / And for the day confined to fast in fires / Till the foul crimes done in days of nature / Are burnt and purged away” (1.5.10–13). Several modes of ghost-belief and ghost-practice intersect here, including the ghosts of classical times that returned to demand proper burial, and the ghosts of earlier English drama—notably Thomas Kyd’s *Spanish Tragedy* (written ca. 1587)—that framed their plays with calls for revenge. In terms of the history of early modern drama in English, *Hamlet* is the centerpiece between a relatively early play like *The Spanish Tragedy*, with its Ghost, its play-within-the-play in “sundry languages,” and its mad and mourning hero, Hieronimo, and a relatively late play like *The Revenger’s Tragedy*, in which the skull of the revenger’s dead beloved becomes his apt and unerring device to entrap her seducer, and in which the hero, emblematically named Vindice, is finally hoist by his own petard. This progression from ghost to skull will, as we will see, be indicative of the way *Hamlet* itself progresses from the past to the future.

One significant piece of onstage evidence that we have about the status of the Ghost comes from its own language, a language that is in part a reflection of Hamlet’s inner consciousness, telling him what he already suspects and intuitively feels, but is also, and crucially, the voice of a world that has ceased to be. “List, Hamlet, list, O list!” (1.5.22). “Of life, of crown, of queen at once dispatched” (1.5.75). “Unhouseled, dis-appointed, unaneled” (1.5.77). “O horrible, O horrible, most horrible!” (1.5.80).

"Adieu, adieu, Hamlet" (1.5.91). Derived in part from contemporary translations of the tragedies of Seneca, this is a language that Shakespeare has already burlesqued in the "Pyramus and Thisbe" play in *A Midsummer Night's Dream*—a play clearly intended by its actors to rival the best and most solemn of ancient classical tragedies. "And thou, O wall, O sweet and lovely wall" (*Dream* 5.1.172). "O grim-looking night, O night with hue so black, / O night which ever art when day is not" (168–169). "And farewell friends, / Thus Thisbe ends. / Adieu, adieu, adieu" (332–334). (This is the rhetorical figure known as the tricolon.) The same triplets and the same repetitions haunt the Ghost's language. The Ghost in *Hamlet* speaks, then, out of a literary and dramatic tradition as well as a personal and private past. His speech is more than medieval autobiography; it is epic drama. The stately majesty of these triplets—"List, Hamlet, list, O list!"—recalls a lost language and a half-forgotten world. Thus old Hamlet emerges in costume, language, and message as the embodiment of lost epic and heroic values, the tutelary spirit of a heroic past. This is as significant for his role in the play as his association with the purgatorial wanderings of the unshrived spirit, for he is a spirit of revenge, first cousin not only to Senecan and Elizabethan ghosts but also to the figure of Patroclus in the *Iliad*. Like Patroclus, he reappears to press his reluctant champion into action in an epic world.

As always in trying to untangle these questions of history, culture, and affect, our best guide will be the play itself, which teaches even as it tests and tempts. Let us ask, then: What we do know about old Hamlet when

we first encounter him in act 1? We know, from his first appearance, what he looks like. He appears to the sentries and to Hamlet “[a]rmed at all points exactly, cap-à-pie” (1.2.200), clad again in “complete steel,” in armor from head to toe. Not for him the soft silks and furs of the Claudius court, or the carefully “rich, not gaudy” costumes of the worldling Laertes, or the posturings of the popinjay Osric. Polonius is right, despite himself: in this play the apparel does proclaim the man. “Such was the very armour he had on,” says Horatio,

When he th ambitious Norway combated.
So frowned he once when in an angry parley
He smote the sledded Polacks on the ice.

1.1.59-62

The armor worn by old Hamlet is the same he wore when he defeated “the ambitious Norway”—and who was Norway but old Fortinbras, the father of the young Fortinbras who will be first Hamlet's rival, and then his chosen successor. The drama seems to be playing itself out, over and over, in a cyclical fashion. Old Fortinbras fights with old Hamlet, young Fortinbras with young Hamlet: the dramatic movement here is one of repetition and reversal. And the defeat of Norway came, significantly, in the epic style, in single combat, man against man, a heroic struggle. Old Hamlet defended his country against invaders from outside, and not, as now—and as we saw in the confusions of the very first scene—from civil

strife within. We are meant, I think, to feel the difference between this ancient warrior in full steel, wielding his heavy weapons, and the chosen weapon of the new Denmark—and the new England—the rapier, Laertes' pride. Fencing schools, like theaters, were located by statute in the Liberties, or outskirts of London. The Italian sword master Rocco Bonetti established a school of arms in London in 1576, and in 1590 Vincentio Saviolo arrived, and published in 1595 a two-volume treatise on the *duello*, explaining the use of the rapier and dagger, and setting out rules for “honorable Quarrels.” But the rapier, despite its lethal effects (an Elizabethan statute of 1562 ordered that “no man shall ... wear any sword, rapier, or any weapon ... passing the length of one yard and half a quarter of blade at the uttermost”),⁸ was a weapon of sport and private quarrel, not a weapon of war. The final fencing match between Hamlet and Laertes, staged, at Claudius's behest, ostensibly as a friendly challenge, a scene of public sport, marks a deliberate and forceful contrast with the previous offstage epic combat between the warriors of an earlier generation, in which, as Horatio reported, “our valiant Hamlet”—that is, old Hamlet—“[d]id slay this Fortinbras” and inherit “by a seal'd compact / Well ratified in law and heraldry” all the lands old Fortinbras possessed (1.1.83–88).

What else do we know about old Hamlet as the play begins? The same contrast between old and new, heroic and fallen, manifest in the two kinds of martial combat that frame the play can be discerned in the imagery Hamlet uses to describe his idealized father. He consistently

chooses the language of heroic myth, so that, comparing old Hamlet to Claudius, he will say, "So excellent a king, that was to this / Hyperion to a satyr" (1.2.139–140). Later he will offer a similar description to his mother:

Hyperion's curls, the front of Jove himself
An eye like Mars, to threaten or command,
A station like the herald Mercury
New lighted on a heaven-kissing hill ...

3.4.55–58

These are Titans and Olympian gods, classical and pagan, not Christian. They seem to belong in the world of the first speech that Hamlet urges on the traveling players, the world of vengeful Pyrrhus, and of good grandsire Priam and his loyal wife Hecuba, and the fall of the great kingdom of Troy. We will have more to say about this old play, but even from the first it is important to note that King Hamlet is cast from the same ideal and heroic mold.

Old Hamlet is the voice of an older age of stable values, but his values are ultimately inadmissible in a world not of fathers but of sons. His are the ideals against which the play will measure itself. But it is no accident of theatrical construction that the Ghost drops out of the play, leaving the action in the hands and voices of the new men, the political men, Hamlet, Laertes, and Fortinbras, each of whom is in a way more like

Octavius Caesar than like Julius Caesar. Hamlet is often compared to Brutus, since both spend so much of their onstage time ruminating on the human condition, often in passages of incomparable poetry that echo the thoughts and debates of contemporary philosophers. But Hamlet, as we will see once again, is finally an “action hero,” not only a philosopher. And his mentors are many, not one: old Hamlet, Claudius, the First Player, Laertes, and Fortinbras, to name just a few.

Yet in another way the Ghost does have a controlling part in the events that follow upon his spectral appearances. “I could,” he says to Hamlet, “a tale unfold whose lightest word / Would harrow up thy soul” (1.5.15–16). Notice the recurrence of this word “unfold,” from the initial challenge of the opening scene (“Who’s there?” “Nay, answer me. Stand and unfold yourself”). The whole play is in some sense a process of unfolding, then folding, and unfolding again. Though he does not tell his tale of purgatory, the Ghost tells another tale, equally mythic, that dominates and pulls together language, imagery, and action in *Hamlet* as a whole. The tale he unfolds is the story of his own death, the answer to the questions we have been asking ourselves since the opening of the play: What happened to old Hamlet? What has caused the sickness in the state? Even the tone of this tale is mythic, otherworldly. It is a kind of inset allegory or emblem, a grim and timeless myth recounted within the tauter, more ornate, Renaissance fabric of the surrounding drama:

'Tis given out that, sleeping in mine orchard,

A serpent stung me. So the whole ear of Denmark
Is by a forgèd process of my death
Rankly abused. But know, thou noble youth,
The serpent that did sting thy father's life
Now wears his crown.

.....

Sleeping within mine orchard,
My custom always of the afternoon,
Upon my secure hour thy uncle stole
With juice of cursèd hebenon in a vial,
And in the porches of mine ears did pour
The leperous distilment....

1.5.35-40, 59-64

Let us look for a moment at the anatomy of this fable. It is in structure a kind of Eden myth, taking place in a medieval *hortus conclusus*, an enclosed garden. Old Hamlet, the innocent upholder of ancient values, sleeping in a garden, is set upon by the serpent, Claudius, whose world is motivated by the satanic basic appetites of lust, pride, envy, and the desire for power. This fable has a peculiar and far-reaching resonance. Positioned as it is near the beginning of the play, the story will come to mind again and again as the changes are rung on its basic values. In effect it is this play's riddle, the center of its radiating imaginative energy, a

scenario that could also be called its primal scene.

To kill old Hamlet in the garden, with poison in the ears.

The *ears* are everywhere. In the advices of fathers to sons that occupy much of the business of the first act; in the ear of Denmark, which is, in the Ghost's phrase, "abused;" and in the whole process of eaves-dropping: Polonius dispatching Reynaldo to spy on Laertes and uncover information on his reputation; Claudius and Polonius behind the arras, or curtain, listening to Hamlet and Ophelia; Claudius sending for Rosen-crantz and Guildenstern to eavesdrop on Hamlet's plans; Polonius again behind an arras, eavesdropping on Hamlet and Gertrude, stabbed to death this time for his pains. The words that enter like daggers into Ger-tude's ears. Hamlet's question "Will the King hear this piece of work?" (3.2.41). "List, Hamlet, list, O list!" cries the Ghost—hear, O hear. And there is a sense in which he himself pours poison into the ear of Hamlet, inflaming him to agony, soul-searching, and revenge.

To kill old Hamlet in the garden, with poison in the ears.

Poison—the something rotten in the state of Denmark. The whole chain of disease-and-infection imagery that is the most evident of the play's many verbal themes: "thimpostume of much wealth and peace, / That in-ward breaks and shows no cause without / Why the man dies" (4.4.9.17–9.19). The contagion that spreads unwholesomely through the night.

The ulcers beneath the skin, unhealthily cosmeticked over with lies. The poison, above all, of language—of deceit and unctuous pretense, the language of Claudius in his opening speech, the dangerous poison of words, words, words. The words, often, of poisonous *serpents*—not only Claudius, but Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, whom Hamlet will trust, he says, “as I will adders fanged” (3.4.185.2). Serpents, too, with erotic and sexual connotations, a fall from innocence of a special kind. The imagined corruption even of Ophelia. The final engines of poison in the last scene, the poisoned cup and the poisoned rapier, time-honored sexual symbols, both fatal, and taken together (an emblematic scene also staged at the close of *Romeo and Juliet*). The inevitably victorious serpent who is “my lady Worm,” the force of bodily corruption and decay in the graveyard, who reduces to the same indifferent dust the great and the simple, the wicked and the pure. The dust of Alexander stopping a bung-hole, of Julius Caesar turned to clay.

To kill old Hamlet in the garden, with poison in the ears.

An Edenic garden, a garden of attempted innocence. Adam as the first gardener, in the gravedigger's mordant joke. Gertrude, whose act “takes off the rose / From the fair forehead of an innocent love / And sets a blister there” (3.4.41–43), joining together the themes of infection and the garden. Hamlet, “[t]hexpectancy and rose of the fair state,” in Ophelia's phrase (3.1.151). And Ophelia, “rose of May” (4.5.156), whose mad songs

are all too apt in their scattering of flowers, and whose watery death, “[w]hen down the weedy trophies and herself / Fell in the weeping brook” (4.7.145–146), seems to bring to life the language of Hamlet’s first bitter soliloquy: “Fie on’t, ah fie, fie! ’Tis an unweeded garden / That grows to seed” (1.2.135–136). In the tragic action of the play Ophelia becomes a symbolic self-deflowerer, performing ceremonially in her madness what she has been proscribed from doing erotically in her love. All these patterns of intertwined language and action seem to flow from the Ghost’s private myth of murder. Like the poison of which he speaks, his tale, with its call to revenge, “Holds such an enmity with blood of man / That swift as quicksilver it courses through / The natural gates and alleys of the body” (1.5.65–67).

The call to revenge is a call to repetition: to do the act again, to do it back, to repay injury with injury. Revenge *is* repetition, and repetition *is* compulsion. As we have noted, the Ghost in *Hamlet* is a close relative to other ghosts that stalked the early modern stage, ghosts in plays by, among others, Seneca and Kyd. The “revenge play” was a popular part of the early modern repertoire, and Shakespeare continually reworked this genre throughout his career, even in as late a play as *The Tempest*. But part of the conundrum of *Hamlet* is the need to establish some relation between revenge, as a moral dynamic and as a theatrical trope, and forgiveness. When Polonius says he will use the players according to their desert, Hamlet is round in his reply: “God’s bodykins, man, much better. Use every man after his desert, and who should scape whipping? Use

them after your own honour and dignity" (2.2.508–510). Here is Hamlet's version of the Golden Rule, akin to Portia's courtroom plea on behalf of the "quality of mercy." Those readers who have regarded this complicated play as one that marks a cultural turning point between the endless cycle of revenge and the transformative power of a Christian acceptance ("the readiness is all") have tacitly assimilated it to the dialectic of Old and New Law. Yet as with Portia, so also with Hamlet (and *Hamlet*), the voicing of a religious commonplace is nuanced and undercut by the dramatic context. Hamlet may well wish the players a generous reception, and surely he misses no opportunity to puncture the empty platitudes of Polonius. But he remains a revenger, though a revenger with a conscience and a consciousness. His attraction to revenge and his resistance to it are part of the intellectual tension that makes Hamlet such an engaged and engaging character. In this play, revenge—like the Ghost—goes underground. Francis Bacon famously wrote that "Revenge is a kind of Wilde Justice; which the more Mans Nature runs to the more ought Law to weed it out.... Certainly, in taking *Revenge*, A Man is but even with his Enemy; But in passing it over, he is Superior: For it is a Princes part to Pardon."⁹ Whatever Hamlet's own view, though, the tempering of justice with mercy, the exploration of both the political and the ethical expediency of revenge's aftermath in reconciliation and forgiveness, is a principal preoccupation of *Hamlet*, as it is of many of the plays that surround it chronologically—*The Merchant of Venice*, *Measure for Measure*, and *All's Well That Ends Well*. There is good reason for earlier

critics to have considered grouping *Hamletw'ith* the “problem plays.”

The ghost of old Hamlet appears to the audience as a virtuous and positive force, recalling a decaying kingdom to the time of its pride and strength. But the values the Ghost espouses are not so easily recaptured or restored. The serpent has entered the garden, and the Edenic world, like the world of heroic myth, has given way to a world whose keynote is mortality. If Adam was the first gardener, he was also the first to come to dust—to what Hamlet will call the “quintessence of dust,” in a speech that closely parallels one of the most famous of all Renaissance humanist documents, Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man*. But where Pico celebrated the mutability of mankind, Hamlet regards it with suspicion, even with dread. Here is Pico:

[U]pon man, at the moment of his creation, God bestowed seeds pregnant with all possibilities, the germs of every form of life. Whichever of these a man shall cultivate, the same will mature and bear fruit in him. If vegetative, he will become a plant; if sensual, he will become brutish; if rational, he will reveal himself a heavenly being; if intellectual, he will be an angel and the son of God. And if, dissatisfied with the lot of all creatures, he should recollect himself into the center of his own unity, he will there, become one spirit with God, in the solitary darkness of the Father, Who is set above all things, himself transcend all creatures. Who then will not look with awe upon this our chameleon, or who, at least, will look with

greater admiration on any other being?¹⁰

And here, by contrast, is Hamlet, framing his words with a vision of a sterile earth on the one hand and an empty human future on the other, so that the passage itself progresses from dust to dust:

[T]his goodly frame, the earth, seems to me a sterile promontory.
This most excellent canopy the air, look you, this brave o'er-
hanging, this majestical roof fretted with golden fire—why, it ap-
pears no other thing to me than a foul and pestilent congregation
of vapors. What a piece of work is a man! How noble in reason, how
infinite in faculty, in form and moving
how express and admirable, in action how like an angel, in appre-
hension how like a god—the beauty of the world, the paragon of
animals! And yet to me what is this quintessence of dust?

2.2.289–298

In such a world, what is real, and what is illusory? The Ghost is called an “illusion,” yet in some sense he is “real.” He is seen by several persons, including the trustworthy and unimpressible Horatio, as well as by the spectators in the theater. He speaks to Hamlet, and what he says seems also “real,” if Hamlet’s “prophetic soul” is to be trusted, since the news the Ghost imparts is expected news, truth, not fiction. Yet the kind of world the Ghost proposes and remembers is in some sense illusory. It

belongs to mortality and to past history, and if Hamlet is to find the “real” for himself he must seek it in a different kind of illusion. That is what we will see him do in the subsequent action of the play. Assuming his “antic disposition”—his mask of modernity, his costume of the fool—Hamlet finds an electric gaiety and release with the players. He is free to act through imagination and through art and improvisation as he cannot do in politics or in the world of decaying Denmark. While the players are only maskers, and their play is fiction, and their passions are but a dream of passion, there is a way in which their brand of intentional illusion is more trustworthy, and more open to Hamlet, than is the way of the Ghost. It is fitting that “the play’s the thing” wherein he will seek to catch the conscience of the King.

Many of the questions that have troubled readers of *Hamlet*—and actors seeking the arc of his character—have tended to be about Hamlet’s behavior and motivation:

- What has caused him to lose all his “mirth” even before he sees the Ghost?
- Is the emotion that grips him, whatever it is, appropriate to its cause? Or is it, as T. S. Eliot suggested, “emotion in excess of the facts as they appear”? Eliot concluded that, in part because Hamlet’s emotion lacks this “objective correlative,” the play, despite its many compelling aspects, is “certainly an artistic failure.”¹¹

- Why does Hamlet feign madness? Or *is* it feigned? Does he change, from first act to last? Why can he kill Claudius in the last act, and not at the beginning of the play?
- Finally, most centrally, why does he delay? Does he doubt the truth of the Ghost's message? Is he too cowardly to kill for revenge? Is he unfit to be a hero? This is what the German poet Goethe thought. Is Hamlet a habitual procrastinator, who shirks all his obligations, including the obligation to revenge? This is what the English Romantic critic and poet Coleridge thought. Is he a prey to melancholy, that fashionable Elizabethan complaint that also grips Antonio in *The Merchant of Venice* and Orsino in *Twelfth Night*? This is what the Victorian critic A. C. Bradley thought. Or is he perhaps not delaying at all, but acting as swiftly as opportunity presents?

Another Victorian critic, E. P. Vining, suggested that the answer to the problem was that Hamlet was really a woman in disguise, and that this accounted for both “his” reluctance to fight and “his” famous delay¹² Vining was writing at a time when a good deal of scholarship on gender ambiguity and erotic types was being written, and being read, by such influential figures as Havelock Ellis and Edward Carpenter. In fact, part of what made Vining believe that the “mystery” of Hamlet was his/her gender was precisely the fact that Shakespeare's character seemed to behave in ways that some observers in the late nineteenth century

regarded as unmanly. "The question may be asked," he wrote, "whether Shakespeare, having been compelled by the course and exigencies of the drama to gradually modify his original hero into a man with more and more of the feminine element, may not at last have had the thought dawn upon him that this womanly man might be in very deed a woman ... ?"¹³ Vining's speculations were influential in the production of a 1920 German silent film version of *Hamlet*, starring the Danish actress Asta Nielsen. In the film, the Danish throne can be occupied only by a male heir, so the female Hamlet is brought up as a man in order to provide political continuity and avoid the loss of Danish lands to arch-foe Norway. The resulting script produced some highly eroticized scenes with a Horatio who does not know Hamlet's secret, and a deathbed revelation of her true gender. The part of Hamlet has not infrequently been played by actresses, including Sarah Bernhardt in 1899 and, more recently, Diane Venora in 2000. "I cannot see Hamlet as a man," Bernhardt declared, when asked about her characterization. "The things he says, his impulses, his actions entirely indicate to me that he was a woman."

In Shakespeare's own time, not only the Player Queen but also the "real" queen, Gertrude, and Ophelia, too, would have been played by boys, so that these nineteenth-and twentieth-century dislocations in the other direction are not, perhaps, so out of keeping. But what is really worth noting here is the connection, in *Hamlet*, between femaleness and excessive emotion, indeed, between femaleness and excessive desire. Many critics have written well on this question, including Janet Adelman

and Jacqueline Rose. Hamlet's own fevered imagination thinks of Gertrude as herself a slave to sexual passion—living “[i]n the rank sweat of an enseamed bed, / Stewed in corruption, honeying and making love / Over the nasty sty—” (3.4.81–83). He tells her:

You cannot call it love, for at your age
The heyday in the blood is tame, it's humble,
And waits upon the judgment....

3.4.67–69

“[F]railty, thy name is woman” is his verdict on his mother's hasty marriage to Claudius a month after her husband's death (1.2.146). Thus some recent criticism has focused on the too easy assumption of Gertrude's “guilt”—on the extraordinary, excessive emotion her son shows in this closet, or private room, this most intimate of spaces, more private than the bedchamber of state into which she has been manipulated into admitting a spy, Polonius—blaming her not only for her new marriage, but also for that of which she has no knowledge, the murder of her former husband. She *is* guilty: of being a woman.

Female sexual desire is, in Hamlet's mind, and therefore in the minds of many influential critics of the play, something out of control. It leads to marriage or to madness—to Ophelia's mad songs, so disturbingly erotic that even Horatio is dismayed. And this depiction of women's emotions as too frail and too powerful, taken together with the sense

that Hamlet is preeminently the figure of consciousness, interiority, and thought, has led, in the reception of the play, to an interesting cultural effect: women, from Sarah Bernhardt on, have often aspired to be Hamlet, rather than Gertrude or Ophelia—not because Hamlet is a woman, but because “mankind” is Hamlet.

Perhaps the most celebrated and influential set of answers to the question “Why does Hamlet delay?” was offered by Sigmund Freud and by his English disciple and fellow psychoanalyst Ernest Jones. Freud's theory of the “Oedipus complex” uses the story of Sophocles' Oedipus, who literally kills his father and marries his mother (though in both cases he does so unknowingly), as the manifest and mythic version of what Freud tended to regard as a latent desire, best exemplified in its more modern, and repressed, form in *Hamlet*. In *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900) he offers a powerful and provocative reading of the Shakespearean character: “Hamlet is able to do anything—except take vengeance on the man who did away with his father and took that father's place with his mother, the man who shows him the repressed wishes of childhood realized.”¹⁴ He summarizes his argument about Hamlet in a letter to his friend Wilhelm Fliess: “How does he explain his irresolution in avenging his father by the murder of his uncle ... ? How better than through the torment he suffers from the obscure memory that he himself had contemplated the same deed against his father out of passion for his mother ... ?”¹⁵ Claudius has “popp'd in between thelection and [his] hopes,” and also between his mother and himself. Then why does Hamlet delay

in killing this hated rival, Claudius? Because, Ernest Jones explains in *Hamlet and Oedipus* (1949), Hamlet recognizes that Claudius has in fact done what he, Hamlet, wished in fantasy to do: murdered his father so as to have his mother. Thus, says Jones, Hamlet hesitates. How can he kill Claudius for acting on desires that Hamlet himself has had? This is what Freud terms, in *The Interpretation of Dreams*, the “secular advance of repression in the emotional life of mankind.” Freud’s hypothesis—which also inspired a famous production and its film version, Laurence Olivier’s 1948 *Hamlet*—recognizes a key structural component of Shakespeare’s play, the presence of several father figures rather than a single father: the dead (idealized) old Hamlet, a martial warrior; the living, despised Claudius, who is King (and Gertrude’s lover) in Hamlet’s stead; and Polonius, the father as “wretched, rash, intruding fool,” who can be killed by accident or mistake (“Is it the King?” Hamlet asks his mother, having stabbed the hidden intruder behind the arras). As we will continue to see, this technique of “splitting,” producing several versions of a character type split into component aspects, is one of the most effective devices of *Hamlet*, and will culminate in Hamlet’s dying recognition that all his rivals and friends (Horatio, Laertes, Fortinbras, the First Player) are in some ways aspects of himself.

We have noticed that the play is built on the comparison and contrast of various kinds of illusion: the apparently real illusion of the Ghost, verified by the evidence of Hamlet’s eyes and ears, and by the apparent truth of his report; the patently false illusion that is the common

language of the Claudius court, ambition and lust hypocritically pretending to be sympathy and mourning; and the deliberately fictive illusion of the players, the part of the play that is about its own materials, acting and playing. As he does so often, the First Clown, the gravedigger, speaks (like all wise fools in Shakespeare) more truly than he knows, when he ties together the several meanings of the word “act.” “[A]n act hath three branches,” he says, “it is to act, to do, to perform” (5.1.11–12). What is the difference between doing and performing? Why can Hamlet in the early scenes, before his sea voyage to England, “perform”—dramatize—but not “do”—not murder and revenge? Why, instead of running his sword through Claudius in act 1, does he choose instead to follow Polonius's procedure, and “by indirections find directions out”? Why does he arrange the elaborate stratagem of *The Mousetrap* to terrify the King, and fright him, as he says, with false fire?

Hamlet as a play is from the first concerned with playing, and the play offers its spectators not only a series of nested plays, but a series of nested audiences. We watch the sentries watching the Ghost (1.1; 1.4). We watch Claudius and Polonius, the fathers, hidden behind a tapestry curtain, watching Ophelia “loosed” to Hamlet in the lobby (3.1). We watch Polonius, again concealed behind a tapestry, watching Hamlet talking to his mother in her closet (3.4). In the *Mousetrap* scene (3.2), we watch Hamlet watching Claudius watch the Player King and Player Queen. The audience of *Hamlet* never knows, securely, whether it is actor, spectator, or eavesdropper. Thus, for example, Claudius's opening speech to his

court seems straightforward enough, but it soon becomes clear that he is acting a part, the part of a bereaved brother and loving father. He is, in fact, himself a Player King, a man who is King in fiction, and by usurpation. The King is a thing of nothing, as Hamlet will say, under the guise of his own assumed madness, a “play” of its own. And likewise Gertrude is a Player Queen, hiding from the guilty knowledge she may suspect but prefers not to admit, even to herself. If we are not sure of these deceptions within deceptions, we have the voice of Hamlet in the first court scene to remind the audience that there is an “outside” to such complicit fictions. “Seems, madam? ... I know not ‘seems.’”

In the same way, the scene in the Queen's closet is on one level a moment of agonized truth-telling between mother and son. Yet Hamlet's method is deliberately theatrical, holding up a pair of portraits, and demanding, “Look here upon this picture, and on this, / The counterfeit presentment of two brothers” (3.4.52–53). The “pictures” are probably miniatures, locket worn as keepsakes. In productions Hamlet often wears his father's portrait on a chain about his neck, while Gertrude wears that of her new husband, Claudius. Hamlet's violent yoking of the two together will thus juxtapose not only the images of the two brothers, but also the heads of Hamlet and Gertrude. Even more startling, of course, is the fate of the other spectator beside ourselves, the hapless Polonius, feeling safely protected behind the arras that conceals him, until the sword of Hamlet runs him through. Polonius thinks he is a spectator. By the time he becomes an actor, he has become a corpse. The

confrontation with reality in *Hamlet* often takes this tragic form, and knowledge becomes, almost instantaneously, knowledge of death.

If we look closely we will see that the entire play is structured as a series of scenes each of which is a play-within-the-play. It is no accident that a recognition of the transforming power of fiction and illusion will help Hamlet to objectify his feelings about life, that “fiction” will help him to discover “fact.” He is able to move in the course of the play from a melancholy passivity and contemplation, rather like Orsino's in *Twelfth Night*, to something more like action, by attaining a sense of crucial detachment that allows him to think, do, and plan, as well as feel. He is able to move from the soliloquies, which dominate the first four acts—and which are rightly reckoned among the humanistic beauties of the play—to the active verbs of the final act, which contains no soliloquy, perhaps because there is no longer any need for one. The players and the plays function as a therapeutic displacement for Hamlet, providing spaces in which he can work out his own problems. One more citation from Freud, this time not focused on Shakespeare or on Hamlet but on the general case of memory, may help to make this structural point clear: “[H]e cannot escape from this compulsion to repeat; and in the end we understand that this is his way of remembering.”¹⁶

The characteristic Shakespearean triple pattern (court-country-court) always includes a return from the enchanted place, whether that place is called a green world, a second world, a place of “antistructure” or of carnival. The middle place is often identified with imagination, art, wonder,

and dream (if the play is a comedy or romance), or with wilderness, danger, and madness (if the play is a tragedy). In almost all cases it brings with it an element of disguise and of (temporary) social leveling. There is always a return from this middle place, at least for most of the characters in the play; but those who return often return transformed. People do not come out of the Forest of Arden, or the Athenian wood, or the "heath" in *King Lear* or *Macbeth* (or the Egypt of *Antony and Cleopatra*) the same as they went in. *Hamlet*, too, contains a structure of journey and return. In fact, it contains two such structures, one before the other. The first is an existential journey into the alternative world of the players, while the second is a literal journey to England (where "the men are as mad as he" [5.1.142-143]).

The scene with the players is prefaced, yet again, by a fragment of a play, this time not a dumb show but a rehearsal in progress, as Polonius instructs Reynaldo how best to spy on Laertes. "Take you, as 'twere, some distant knowledge of him, / As thus: 'I know his father and his friends, / And in part him '" (2.1.13-15). Polonius is both playwright and director, though he occasionally forgets his own lines: "[W]hat was I about to say? By the mass, I was about to say something" (2.1.50-51). The whole scene is yet another evidence of the constant and deceitful play-acting in Denmark. Polonius's confidence in his son, loudly voiced to his face, is now exposed as a sham. The father will send a spy to check on his son's behavior. It is this scene that is balanced, with superb effect, by the first news of Hamlet's antic disposition, announced to us through the

familiar Shakespearean device of the “unscene,” a vivid event that takes place offstage and is reported—in this case by the guileless Ophelia:

Lord Hamlet, with his doublet all unbraced,
No hat upon his head, his stockings fouled,
Ungartered, and down-gyvèd to his ankle,
Pale as his shirt, his knees knocking each other ...

2.1.79–82

Ophelia is a naïve and completely believable witness who brings this off-stage scene to vivid life. She is one of the few Shakespearean women who can never break away from the sway of a parent. In her innocent account of Hamlet's appearance in her room we have a vision, not so much of one man's madness as of the madness of the world, the madness of the human condition. In contrast to Polonius's insinuating script, which must be memorized, and his tedious, far from brief, “words, words, words” (“More matter with less art,” the exasperated Queen will implore him [2.2.97]), Ophelia's description of the antic Hamlet seems more like another dumb show, a silent apparition:

He took me by the wrist and held me hard,
Then goes he to the length of all his arm,
And with his other hand thus o'er his brow
He falls to such perusal of my face

As a would draw it. Long stayed he so.
At last, a little shaking of mine arm,
And thrice his head thus waving up and down,
He raised a sigh so piteous and profound
As it did seem to shatter all his bulk
And end his being. That done, he lets me go,
And, with his head over his shoulder turned,
He seemed to find his way without his eyes,
For out o' doors he went without their help,
And to the last bended their light on me.

2.1.88-101

In its way this is very like the first mysterious appearance of the Ghost: pale, silent, beckoning, waving his arms, disappearing into darkness. Hamlet has in effect *become* a ghost. And Ophelia's report of his demeanor is enough of an "inexplicable dumb show" to generate misinterpretations. "This is the very ecstasy of love," concludes Polonius. Stereotypical lovers, at least in literature, did indeed sometimes present themselves in this kind of disarray—Rosalind describes such a lover in very similar terms in *As You Like It*—and Claudius is of course eager to agree with this diagnosis. But Gertrude has other suspicions: "I doubt it is no other but the main— / His father's death and our o'erhasty marriage" (2.2.56-57).

Everyone is an actor and a director. Polonius proudly acknowledges that he “played once i'th university” (3.2.89–90). “I did enact Julius Caesar,” he says. “I was killed i'th capitol” (3.2.93). This is probably Shakespeare's joke about his company, for *Julius Caesar* was written and staged in the same years as *Hamlet*, and the actor who played Polonius could well have been seen by the same audience on another afternoon in the role of Caesar. But there is dramatic irony as well as an in-joke here, for ultimately Polonius will suffer a bathetic version of Caesar's death by stabbing. Polonius casts Hamlet in two of his own plays, the “loosing” of Ophelia in the lobby in act 3, scene 1 (watched, as we have noted, by Claudius and Polonius), and the episode in Gertrude's closet in act 3, scene 4, in which again he positions himself as a hidden spectator. Notice that Shakespeare places these two corrupt and cynical “plays” on either side of Hamlet's *Mousetrap* in act 3, scene 2.

The victim of social actors, Hamlet becomes one. He sees that the world around him is peopled by pretenders, that only those who know they are actors are “real.” It is for that reason extremely appropriate for the players to appear, as if on cue. They have been conjured out of Hamlet's own imagination. The syllogism works something like this: Hamlet realizes that he is an actor, and that everyone in Elsinore is playing a role; the players arrive at the court and are announced. And they will disappear the same way, when their job is done. With the arrival of the players, the function of illusion in the play begins to shift. Hamlet begins to use it, and to use the players and their repertoire, to investigate his own

society—as well as himself.

Before coming to the great play scene, however, it will be helpful, I think, to say a word about the play, or fragment of a play, that precedes *The Mousetrap*, because that older play is very much part of Hamlet's quest for answers. In act 2, scene 2, he asks the First Player to recite a speech from "Aeneas' tale to Dido," a speech that had apparently impressed him so much that he is able to recite much of it from memory. (Memory, and verbal memorization, are among the knowledge arts of the play, alongside reading and "writing fair," like a secretary or a scribe.) The play is about the fall of Troy, long thought by the English to be the source of their own civilization (one name for London was New Troy, or "Troynovant"). Aeneas, taking refuge with Dido in Carthage after fleeing the burning city, tells her the story of its fall. In *Hamlet* Troy seems very like the way Denmark is said to have been during the reign of old Hamlet—golden age, brave, heroic, and warlike. "[R]everend Priam," the old Trojan king, seems in some ways to resemble an idealized old Hamlet, but on the other hand the desperate and grieving Hecuba, Priam's wife, running barefoot up and down, is sharply contrasted to Gertrude, who married again so quickly after her husband's death that "[t]he funeral baked meats / Did coldly furnish forth the marriage tables" (1.2.179–180). Pyrrhus, an avenger dressed in black ("he whose sable arms, / Black as his purpose ..." [2.2.432–433]), first pauses with his sword in the air, and then acts, avenging the death of his father. In short, Troy emerges from

this speech, one Hamlet so fondly remembers, as a picture of what might have been, what should have been, an epic ideal. Like Hamlet's parting glance at Ophelia, looking over his shoulder, bending his eyes on her—and like the message from the Ghost, “List, Hamlet, list, O list!”—this is for Hamlet a look backward, at a different kind of world, a lost world. Here at the play's midpoint it is his last glance backward, and it accomplishes something crucial for both the character and the play. Through the players, though fiction, he finds not only emotion—a way of engaging and accessing his own suppressed and unarticulated feelings—but also what he so badly needs and longs for: action. He is ready to catch the conscience of the King—in a play. “Action” and “passion” are two sides of the same coin, here not so much opposites as counterparts of each other.

The play Hamlet chooses to confront and entrap Claudius is very different from the Pyrrhus play, “Aeneas' tale to Dido.” The Pyrrhus speech came from a play with familiar epic values—Polonius, not surprisingly, found it classical and boring, not relevant to anything he knew or cared about. But *The Mousetrap*, or, to give it its other name, “The Murder of Gonzago,” is a thriller, a modern (which is to say, a Renaissance) melodrama, a play of political intrigue. “The story is extant,” says Hamlet, “and writ in choice Italian” (3.2.240). Modern, current (or “extant”), and Italian—all harbingers of audience titillation. Italy, the home of Machiavelli, was often presented in English Renaissance drama as the site of scurrilous intrigue and scandal. A playwright had only to set his play there, as Ben Jonson would do with *Volpone* or John Webster with *The Duchess of*

Malfi, he had only to give his characters Italian names, and it would be quite clear to the audience that they were being vouchsafed a glimpse into a world of decadence, sin, and forbidden pleasures—as well as of violence, betrayal, and murder.

In the course of the *Mousetrap* play the spectators first witness a dumb show; then hear a conversation, in rhymed couplets, between Player King and Player Queen; and finally see the entrance of the murderer. Throughout, Hamlet acts as interpreter— a role he will play throughout the larger drama, using his soliloquies and asides as a way of commenting to the offstage audience, just as his interpolations during *The Mousetrap* enlighten and disturb the onstage court. “You are as good as a chorus, my lord” (3.2.224), Ophelia will observe, with characteristic artlessness. Hamlet's glosses are brief and to the point. “This is one Lucianus, nephew to the King,” he will explain as the murderer makes his appearance (3.2.223). Why “nephew” and not, as in the real case of Claudius and old Hamlet, “brother”? This is an explanation with an added menace—a glance backward that is also a glance forward. For it is Hamlet himself who is “nephew” to King Claudius. The past murder and the present threat are combined: Claudius has killed Hamlet's father; the “nephew” quietly announces that he will avenge that murder with another. And then “[t]he King rises,” calling an end to the performance, yet another broken play, perhaps the most famous and most effectively truncated play-within-the-play in all of Shakespeare, structurally akin to “Pyramus and Thisbe” in *A Midsummer Night's Dream* and the pageant of

the “Nine Worthies” in *Love’s Labour’s Lost*, and to Prospero’s masque in *The Tempest*.

But which play has the audience of *Hamlet* been watching? As always, our consciousness is closely knit with Hamlet’s, and Hamlet, clearly, has been watching not the stage but the King. The suspense for him is in what Claudius will or will not reveal, not in the outcome of “The Murder of Gonzago”—an outcome he already knows and that, indeed, he may in part have written in those elusive, added “dozen or sixteen lines.” Once again Claudius and Gertrude are the Player King and the Player Queen. We have been deceived by our eyes again. The play was in the audience. Claudius and Gertrude are the “guilty creatures sitting at a play” of Hamlet’s soliloquy (2.2.566), but they are also the bad actors he criticizes in his advice to the players: “O, there be players that I have seen play, and heard others praise, ... that neither having the accent of Christians nor the gait of Christian, pagan, nor no man ...” (3.2.25–29). The King and Queen are audience, but they are also players, players now caught in Hamlet’s play, caught in *his* mousetrap. Art now acts on life. The play catches the king. What seems to be a mere fiction or fabrication reveals a key truth.

From this moment, from the play’s principal turning point (3.2), Hamlet will himself begin to act, not only in the gravedigger’s sense of “perform,” but also in his sense of “do.” When he next appears, he will act, quickly and without remorse, in his mother’s closet, stabbing behind the arras at the intruder he is sure is Claudius, killing Polonius instead:

Thou wretched, rash, intruding fool, farewell.

I took thee for thy better.

3.4.30-31

The sentiment, and the phrase, recall Prince Hal's epitaph on the fallen Falstaff at Shrewsbury. "Poor Jack, farewell. / I could have better spared a better man" (1 *Henry IV* 5.4.102-103). As it turns out, Falstaff is not really dead. But with the indubitably dead Polonius, Hamlet wastes no time on pathos or pity. He does not even "lug the guts into the neighbour room" (3.4.186) until he has spoken with, and shamed, his mother. The body of Polonius lies onstage, a visceral object lesson and memento mori, throughout the rest of the scene—much as did, in earlier history plays, the coffins of dead kings.

Having "acted"—having killed Polonius—Hamlet is sent on the emblematic journey toward England, and on the journey he will act again, more deliberately this time, with Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, another pair of players, who desired to "play upon" him (3.2.335), but whom he now casts in a play of his own. En route to England, he will tell Horatio, he found the sealed commission they carried to the English King, asking for his death:

Being thus benetted round with villainies—

Ere I could make a prologue to my brains,

They had begun the play...

By that point Hamlet is totally in command of the language of playing, as well as of the play his mind conceives. He changes Claudius's script, writing out a commission for the death of Rosencrantz and Guildenstern, signing it with the name of the King, and sealing it with his father's signet ring, now in some sense rightfully his. He becomes what we could well call a ghostwriter, writing his anonymous script in the name of the Ghost, and for the revenge the Ghost has sought. A signet is both a seal and an official "signature." We may notice that Hamlet is also a skilled scribe or scrivener, who does not hold it, "as our statist[s] [politicians] do, / A baseness to write fair" (5.2.34-35), and is thus able to substitute his own handwritten text for that originally supplied and ordained by the King. This act of ghostwriting is structurally parallel to his earlier substitution of the "dozen or sixteen lines" in the *Mousetrap* play, making it more pointed and pertinent to the situation in the Danish court. (Critics' attempts to locate and identify those "dozen or sixteen lines" have made for a diverting wild goose chase across the centuries; see my essay "MacGuffin Shakespeare" for a fuller account of this amusing phenomenon.¹⁷ "Dozen or sixteen," we should note, is a proverbial, not a specific, phrase, meaning "some lines" rather than literally twelve to sixteen, so any amount of creative counting, or accounting, will fail of its object, rather like the "duc dame" joke in *As You Like It*, where the gullible audience is the butt of Jaques' wit.)

What has happened to Hamlet? How has he changed by entering into the world of serious “play”? As we have already seen, he has changed in costume, moving from his “inky cloak” (an earlier intimation of his future career as a writer of substitute lines and commissions) to his madman's disarray before Ophelia, to his third costume, his traveler's sea-gown, potentially an emblem of more existential journeys and voyages as well as of his own, highly specific and enforced, travel from Denmark toward England. Hamlet has also changed in language and the way he deploys it. The witty, punning, self-protective Hamlet of the opening scenes was also a monologist, a speaker in soliloquies. The *Hamlet* film made by Laurence Olivier established a tradition, much copied, of filming or performing the soliloquies in the play with a voice-over, the actor on screen not moving his lips, so that the effect is one of voiced thought, of an intense and overwhelming consciousness, echoing the Hamlet of the Romantics, as much a “universal” philosopher as an action hero in an early modern revenge tragedy. The major soliloquies, one in each of the first four acts (“O that this too too solid flesh would melt” [1.2.129]; “O, what a rogue and peasant slave am I!” [2.2.527]; “To be, or not to be” [3.1.58]; “How all occasions do inform against me / And spur my dull revenge!” [4.4.9.22–9.23]) are interior monologues, syntactically elaborate, full of self-questioning. The “rogue and peasant slave” soliloquy contains ten questions and nine interpolations, while “To be, or not to be” is almost entirely composed of questions, conditionals, infinitives, and passive constructions: “To be, or not to be;” “To die, to sleep.” But by the

fifth act, after the voyage to England, there are no more soliloquies. Hamlet now talks to others rather than to himself or to the audience, and his language is suddenly full of active verbs, verbs of “doing”:

Up from my cabin,
My sea-gown scarfed about me in the dark,
Groped I to find out them, had my desire,
Fingered their packet, and in fine withdrew
To mine own room again, making so bold,
My fears forgetting manners, to unseal
Their grand commission....

5.2.13-19

There he found the “exact command” that, so soon as it was read (“on the supervise”), “no leisure bated / No, not to stay the grinding of the axe / My head should be struck off.” In the importunacy of this haste he turns to his own devices, substituting, as we have seen, the names (and thus the heads) of Rosencrantz and Guildenstern for his own. *Hamlet* performs this “head trick” in a way quite similar to that in *Measure for Measure*, a play written in the same years, where the head of the hero, Claudio, is spared by the substitution of the head of “[o]ne Ragusine, a most notorious pirate” (4.3.63), who has just conveniently died of a fever. (The preoccupation with pirates in three plays of this period, *Twelfth Night*, *Hamlet*, and *Measure for Measure*, is worth noting. Pirates were a

fact of seagoing life in early modern England and Europe. They are also mentioned by Shylock, a resident of the maritime commercial city of Venice; in some early English history plays; and in the other Shakespeare “sea” plays, *Antony and Cleopatra* and *Pericles*.)

Of all the changes in Hamlet as a dramatic character, though, the most striking is the change in his conception of his own role. From the beginning of the play he has lamented the fact that he is not like other people he admires, and to whom he insistently compares himself. He is not like his father, or Horatio, or Laertes, or Fortinbras—or so he thinks. Two of the four best-known soliloquies take this apparent dissimilarity as their starting-off point. In the “rogue and peasant slave” speech Hamlet compares himself unfavorably to the First Player, who can show strong emotion even in a fictional context, and in “How all occasions do inform against me” he contrasts his slowness in martial revenge with the rapidity and bravery of Fortinbras, the “delicate and tender prince” who leads his troops on a mission of honor, where they “[g]o to their graves like beds” and “fight for a plot / ... Which is not tomb enough and continent / To hide the slain” (4.4.9.38; 4.4.9.52–9.55). Yet Hamlet is very like both the First Player and Fortinbras, and the progress of the play can be measured in part by the progress of his self-recognition in the models he has heretofore seen as indices of his own failure. In using his father's signet ring, as we have seen, he emblematically becomes both King and “Hamlet the Dane.” By the play's last scene he is willing to see correspondences he has long ignored (but which have been evident to the

audience):

But I am very sorry, good Horatio,
That to Laertes I forgot myself;
For by the image of my cause I see
The portraiture of his....

5.2.76–79

And Fortinbras the soldier, whose name means “strong-arm,” ordains for Hamlet, as is most fitting, a soldier's burial.

Hamlet's education in the mutability of roles began with the players, and the First Player's tears, but it ends in the graveyard, with the lesson that all human lives are roles, briefly played. The politician, the courtier, the lawyer, the great buyer of land— “That skull had a tongue in it and could sing once” (5.1.70). The skull of Yorick, the court jester during Hamlet's childhood, is in a way the antitype of the Ghost, material rather than spiritual. But it is also a memento mori, a reminder of death, and thus, like the Ghost, another invitation to “remember.” The anatomist Andreas Vesalius, who in 1543 (more than half a century before *Hamlet*) published his great work *De humani corporis fabrica*, the first complete textbook of human anatomy, included among his illustrations one of a human skeleton deep in contemplation of a skull. This, we might say, is *Hamlet avant la lettre*, an uncanny anticipation of Shakespeare's play. Skulls were common ornaments in the period, yet the skull of Yorick has

a particular local habitation and a name. Hamlet's antic disposition may mirror itself on this first mentor and companion, another surrogate father, now "quite chap-fallen." The graveyard strips human beings to the bare bone, and in this cosmic perspective all roles are equal—"let her paint an inch thick, to this favour she must come." After all the wordiness of others in the play, from Polonius to the foppish courtier Osric to the ruminative Hamlet himself, the gravedigger strips language, like lives, to bare and literal essentials. He does not use metaphor, and he does not respond to it. "Upon what ground?" asks Hamlet, looking for a reason or an explanation, and the reply he receives is, "Why, here in Denmark" (5.1.148–149).

The gravedigger is a literalist, and like so many other clowns in Shakespeare he speaks home truths, even in the apparent guise of malapropism or misunderstanding. "How absolute the knave is!" says Hamlet, with some admiration, to Horatio. "We must speak by the card, or equivocation will undo us" (5.1.126–127). But metaphor is a necessary role for language, and language, as we have seen again and again in these plays, is for Shakespeare the touchstone and index of humanity. So Hamlet, although instructed in the graveyard, will leave it again for the world of roles, for a final choice of identity. "This is I, / Hamlet the Dane," he cries, as—in the Folio's stage direction—he "[l]eaps in the grave" of the dead Ophelia, and then grapples with Laertes for his right to mourn. The image of the two men wrestling in an open grave is itself a stunning and effective visual emblem, while the phrase "Hamlet the Dane" brings

together the private and the public, the man and the nation, Hamlet reclaiming as his own the name and the titles with which the bereaved son, much earlier, greeted the ghost of his father: "I'll call thee Hamlet, King, father, royal Dane" (1.4.25–26).

At the play's close the audience is once again presented with the theatrical metaphor of a dumb show. Hamlet's duel with Laertes, undertaken at the behest of King Claudius, is a staged piece of theater that, like all the other plays-within-the-play, goes tragically wrong. The poisoned cup and the poisoned rapier—again, time-honored sexual symbols in literature, art, and myth—are inadvertently exchanged, so that they wreak their harm on unintended victims. The "union" Claudius ostentatiously drops into the cup of wine ("The King shall drink to Hamlet's better breath, / And in the cup an union shall he throw / Richer than that which four successive kings / In Denmark's crown have worn" [5.2.209–212]) is a jewel—a "union" was a pearl of singular beauty and great value. But the word was also used, in Shakespeare's day as it is now, as a synonym for marriage. Whether or not the poison drunk by Gertrude got into the cup by way of the "union," as some critics have maintained ("The Queen carouses to thy fortune, Hamlet," she says gaily, as the appalled Claudius urges, "Gertrude, do not drink," and then remarks, aside, "It is the poisoned cup; it is too late"), it is the union itself in that other sense, the "o'erhasty marriage" of Claudius and Gertrude, that carries and disperses the poison.

By the end of the scene they are all dead or dying. The duel is followed, then, by the order that the bodies be placed “[h]igh on a stage,” both playing-space and platform, to serve as a silent example. Even in his dying words Hamlet has addressed, not only the spectators upon the stage, but the audience in the theater—in the *language* of the theater:

You that look pale and tremble at this chance,
That are but mutes or audience to this act ...

5.2.276–277

A “mute” is a silent person, and also was, in Shakespeare's time, a silent actor, one who had a nonspeaking role. We are all implicated in the outcome of “this change,” of this tragedy.

But Hamlet's final injunction is to his friend Horatio:

If thou didst ever hold me in thy heart,
Absent thee from felicity a while,
And in this harsh world draw thy breath in pain
To tell my story.

5.2.288–291

The story is to be told to Fortinbras, and to the English ambassador, both representatives of the political world. However, the injunction to “tell my story” is also—as we have seen so often at the close of Shakespearean

tragedy—an injunction to perform the play. In *Romeo and Juliet*, *Othello*, *King Lear*, *Antony and Cleopatra*, in almost every tragedy Shakespeare wrote, this invitation, to “speak of these sad things,” is a way of making tragic events bearable, by retelling them, by placing them at once in the realm of the social and of the aesthetic. It is important to note that Horatio himself cannot really do this. He has not heard the soliloquies, without which the play has a very different quality, far more sensational and inexplicable. “[L]et me speak to th’ yet unknowing world,” he says,

How these things came about. So shall you hear
Of carnal, bloody, and unnatural acts,
Of accidental judgements, casual slaughters,
Of deaths put on by cunning and forced cause;
And, in this upshot, purposes mistook
Fall’n on th’inventors’ heads. All this can I
Truly deliver.

5.2.323–329

This is and is not *Hamlet*.